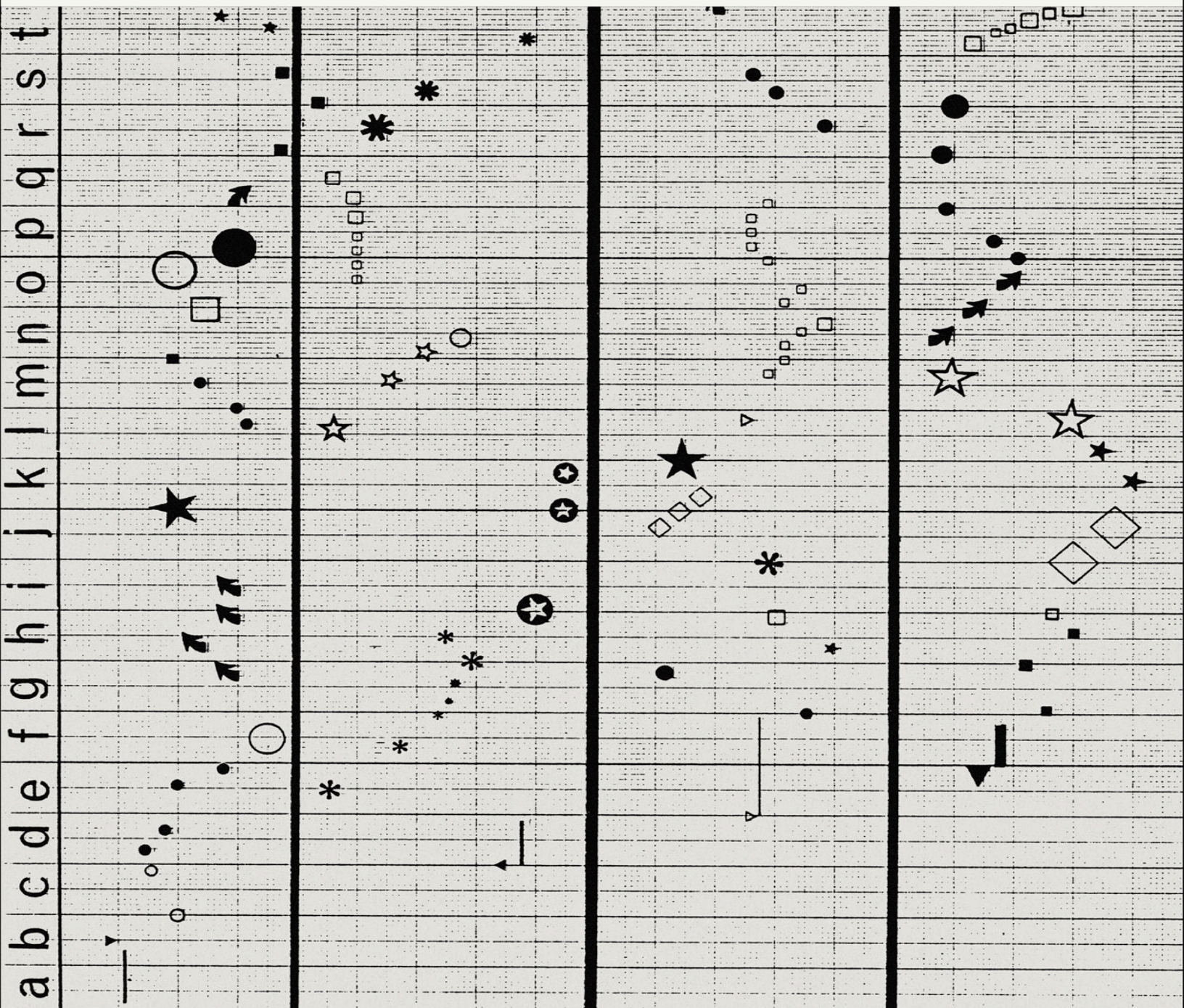




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The Penguin Book of Oulipo

Edited by Philip Terry



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THE PENGUIN BOOK OF OULIPO

Queneau, Perec, Calvino and the Adventure of Form



Introduction

Anticipatory Plagiarism

The *Ouvroir de littérature potentielle* (Workshop of Potential Literature or, in Stanley Chapman's words, Knitting Circle of Potential Literature) was founded in 1960 by Raymond Queneau and François Le Lionnais, with the aim of exploring the benefits of mathematics and rule-based constraints for the writing of literature. One of Oulipo's distinctions, as David Bellos has argued,¹ is its long history – in its now six decades it has already endured far longer than any other structured group in the history of French literature. Yet, long before Oulipo came into existence, its methods were already being used by writers and artists across the globe. One well-known constraint associated with Oulipo, the lipogram, where a text is written without the use of certain predetermined letters, has a long history, stretching back to the *grands rhétoriciens* of sixteenth-century France, and even further back, to rhetorical games played by the Romans and the Greeks. In China, from as early as the third century, a tradition of reversible poems flourished, which reached its apotheosis in the work of Su Hui, who embroidered a grid of 840 characters on silk that could be read in an estimated 12,000 ways. There are the sonnets of Petrarch and Dante, acrostics concealed in the Psalms, the formally complex sestinas of Arnaut Daniel, structured around the permutation of six end-words, and a host of other formal devices and rhetorical structures from the accumulative lists of Homer and Rabelais, to the calligrams of George Herbert and

the alphabetical verses of Christopher Smart's *Jubilate Agno*. Part of Oulipo's project, from its inception, which they called 'anoulipism', was to study the literature of the past to discover formal constraints which could be used in the present, and writers who used such methods they called, not without a sense of humour, 'anticipatory plagiarists'. One perhaps unexpected example of anticipatory plagiarism, of English origin, is to be found in the call changes used by bellringers, whose permutational scores echo the patternings found in the sestina and related forms so beloved of Oulipo. Other important anticipatory plagiarists include Leibniz, for his work on combinatorial mathematics, and, among those included here, Jorge Luis Borges, whose bifurcating narratives anticipate Oulipo's own storytelling experiments (bifurcation is key to the structure of Roubaud's *Mathematics*, for example), Lewis Carroll, and Jonathan Swift, who in *Gulliver's Travels* imagined one of the first writing machines.

Bourbaki

Oulipo, when it was founded, didn't come out of the blue. Queneau had long been interested in structure and mathematics, and he had been an active member of the surrealists, with whom he shared an interest in the unconscious and dreams, though he gradually moved away from this group and its argumentative founder, André Breton. On one level, Oulipo was Queneau's riposte to the surrealists, for if surrealism maintains that writing can be released by the access given to the unconscious in 'automatic writing', Queneau quickly saw that the products of such a process were often the same. By replacing the unconscious with constraint and structure, and thereby enacting a return to neoclassicism, Queneau was proposing that rules are required to facilitate the expression of the truly individual self. Another key influence on Oulipo, often overlooked in accounts in English, is the avant-garde group of mathematicians Bourbaki. For

Jacques Roubaud, it is the link to Bourbaki and mathematics that accounts for much of Oulipo's radical originality, by providing it with a counter-model to the surrealist group. As Roubaud writes: 'There can be no doubt that, when they founded Oulipo, Queneau and Le Lionnais, amateur mathematicians as they were, had this group in mind.'² Bourbaki, a secretive group, aimed to rewrite mathematics and provide it with solid foundations using a single source, Set Theory, and a rigorous system, the Axiomatic Method. For Roubaud, the Oulipo 'translates' Bourbaki into the domain of arts and language, while maintaining that its methods should not be taken to exclude the validity of other approaches. So the members of Oulipo include: (i) writers; (ii) mathematicians; (iii) writer-mathematicians; and (iv) mathematician-writers. When Oulipo began, like Bourbaki it was a semi-clandestine group, though under the influence of Queneau and some younger members it gradually threw off this restriction; it is also, like Bourbaki (and like surrealism) given to collaborative work.

Constraint

The most common description of Oulipo is that it explores constraint-based writing methods. Thus Roubaud writes: 'The aim of Oulipo is to invent (or reinvent) constraints of a formal nature (*contraintes*) and propose them to enthusiasts interested in composing literature.' The word 'constraint', however, while it is hard to find a better single-word substitute, is arguably inadequate to bear the weight of the variety of techniques and approaches explored by Oulipo. So Ian Monk writes: 'personally I dislike the word "constraint" which to me sounds too negative given that the general aim of the group's writers is to find ways to extend their artistic possibilities, not just to pull off extraordinary verbal stunts, which is more the domain of various loose groups who orbit around us.'³ Monk prefers to use terms like 'structure', 'form' or 'technique', words which are echoed in some of the earliest documents relating to Oulipo. One should certainly add

to this the term ‘translation’, for many Oulipian texts, like translations, transform already existing texts, and Oulipo can be credited with inventing the term ‘homolinguistic translation’ to describe translation from, say, French into French. Hidden behind the word ‘constraint’ three principal methods stand out: (i) strict constraints, such as writing without the letter ‘e’, as in Perec’s novel *La Disparition* (*A Void*), or the constraints of form involved in fixed-form poetries; (ii) what Oulipo refer to as ‘combinatorial literature’, as in Raymond Queneau’s *Cent mille milliards de poèmes* (*A Hundred Thousand Billion Poems*); and (iii) techniques of transforming or ‘translating’ existing texts, such as their famous N+7 method, where all nouns are changed by going on seven places in a dictionary: ‘To be, or not to be, that is the quiche.’

Dossier 17 of the College of 'Pataphysics

When Oulipo was first set up it became a sub-commission of the College of 'Pataphysics at the request of Raymond Queneau, and its first collective publication, *Exercices de littérature potentielle* (*Exercises in Potential Literature*), was published as Dossier 17 of the College in 1961. Here, in the ‘First Manifesto’, François Le Lionnais argues that all literature is subject to ‘constraints’ and ‘procedures’ – the three unities of classical tragedies for example – and he announces the goal of Oulipo as being to explore and discover new possibilities for writing in this domain with the aid of computers and mathematics. ‘Anoulipism’, as we’ve seen, denotes the analytical tendency in Oulipo, analysing the literature of the past to discover already-existing constraints; ‘synthoulipism’ describes the ‘essential vocation’ of Oulipo, the invention of new constraints. The rest of the collection contains Oulipo’s first experiments: examples of the N+7 method (a particular case of the $W \pm n$ method, where ‘W’ stands for any word, ‘n’ for any number); Queneau’s ‘Redundancy in Phane Armé’, where he removes all but a handful of words at the end of the lines in

sonnets by Mallarmé to create new poems (a technique which has much in common with that of ‘erasure’ practised in, for example, Tom Phillips’ treated Victorian text *A Humument*); Le Lionnais’s ‘Attempts at the Limit’, where he reduces a poem to a single word (‘Fenouil’ or ‘Fennel’), a single letter (‘T.’), and writes a poem based on punctuation (ideas which would later influence other Oulipians of minimalist persuasion, like Michèle Métail); and Bourbaki-inspired excursions based on set theory such as the idea of the ‘intersective novel’, a genre which takes its vocabulary from the shared lexicons of two different novels. Today, Oulipo is completely independent from the College of ‘Pataphysics, and some members of Oulipo have little or no connection to the College, but it continues to have a subliminal influence on the work of the group. One thing which profoundly links the two groups together is the symbol of the spiral or *gidouille* – it is not only the symbol *par excellence* of ‘Pataphysics, appearing as it does on Ubu’s chest, but it is the central symbol of Italo Calvino’s *Cosmicomics*, and its circling motion describes the Fibonacci sequence and suggests the intricate patternings of the sestina, a form of central importance to the thinkings of Oulipo. And if you want to relinquish membership the bizarre ritual is nothing if not pataphysical: suicide in the presence of an officer of the court who must ascertain that in the Oulipian’s last wishes they were committing suicide to be released from Oulipo.

Elementary Morality

Among the examples of ‘synthoulipism’ that stand out is the poetic form which has come to be known as the ‘elementary morality’ after Queneau’s 1975 volume of the same title. David Bellos describes the form as follows:

Three two-line stanzas, line 1 of each consisting of three phrases and line 2 of one phrase, each formed by a noun-

adjective pair

followed by

Seven lines of at least two and not more than seven syllables

followed by

One two-line stanza conforming to the same constraint as at the start⁴

Queneau created the form out of the least Oulipian of all poetic sources – inspiration – but he noted in his diary that the form could be used to ‘do Oulipo’. Queneau first named the form *lipolepse* (from the Greek for ‘leaving out’ and ‘taking in’), but Oulipo have come to refer to the form more familiarly as the ‘elementary morality’ or, on occasions, the ‘quennet’, as it has one more line than the sonnet. While it has not yet become the canonical form that the sonnet is, it has been used and adapted by many writers both inside and outside Oulipo, including the present author, and several examples of the form are included here, from those of Queneau, Valérie Beaudouin and Frédéric Forte to English versions by Robert Sheppard, writing as René Van Valckenborch.

Foulipo

See under *Noulipo*.

Georges Perec

‘One of the most singular literary personalities in the world’, is how the Italian fabulist and fellow-Oulipian Italo Calvino once described Georges Perec. And while Perec was already an accomplished writer before he was co-opted by the Oulipo in March 1967 – his novel *Things* had won the Prix Renaudot in 1965 – his encounter with the Oulipo was explosive and played a major part in launching Oulipo onto the world stage. Perec’s e-less novel, *La Disparition* (*A Void*),

appeared in 1969; and his monumental *Life A User's Manual*, where an invented Parisian apartment block is divided into squares like a chess board, and the order of chapters determined by the moves of a knight across the board (which is only to scratch the surface of the constraints Perec employed here) appeared in 1978, winning the Prix Médicis.

Heteromorphism

Oulipo, however, cuts across genres, and much of Perec's brilliance is not to be found in the novels he became famous for, but in his almost uncanny versatility: before his early death from lung cancer in 1982, Perec had composed uniquely dazzling essays on topics from spectacles to meditations on place, voluminous collections of poems based on constraints of his own devising, plays and film scripts, the longest palindrome in the French language (or any other language, for that matter), which gained him an entry in the *Guinness Book of Records*, memoirs such as *W or The Memory of Childhood* and *I Remember* (a uniquely French take on Joe Brainard's book of the same title), and many beguiling shorter texts, such as the brief story *The Winter Journey*, a parable of 'anticipatory plagiarism'. If Oulipo is an exploration of 'potential literature' – in the sense of creating new possibilities for literature – it is fair to say that this potential was realized nowhere more so than in the figure of Georges Perec. Yet Perec was as aware as anybody that Oulipian methods in themselves were no guarantee of artistic success. In *Life A User's Manual* the painter Hutting devises an elaborate formula for his portraits, where colour is dictated by the date and time of the painting's 'birth' and the phase of the moon at the painting's 'conception': 'The system's impersonality,' Perec writes, 'was the kind of thing to captivate Hutting. But perhaps because he applied it too rigidly, he obtained results more disconcerting than captivating.'

Italo Calvino

Co-opted by Oulipo in 1973, though his awareness of Oulipo dates to somewhat earlier, Calvino brought a wealth of experience as a writer to Oulipo, and his own writing took on a new turn as he increasingly experimented with potential literature, with the production of a number of books of an explicitly Oulipian nature, including *The Castle of Crossed Destinies*, which conjures stories of high adventure out of combinations of tarot cards, and *If on a Winter's Night a Traveller*, which gently satirises Oulipo in its invented New York collective the OEPHLW (Organization for the Electronic Production of Homogenized Literary Works).⁵ In his 1967 lecture 'Cybernetics and Ghosts' Calvino states that: 'writing is purely and simply a process of combination among given elements.' This approach to storytelling, where story elements are combined and recombined to generate all the possible outcomes of a narrative, is present in many of Calvino's stories, from his computer-driven combinatorial detective story 'The Burning of the Abominable House', which Calvino presented to the Oulipo in November 1972, to his meta-story 'The Count of Monte Cristo', but it perhaps has its origins in his work on the traditional tales he collected in his monumental volume *Italian Folktales*. Here Calvino learnt how tellers of folktales could recombine a set of given elements in an almost infinite variety of ways to create the warp and woof of the world's stories. The storyteller's instinct to rearrange and improvise on a given theme is echoed in Le Lionnais's 'Second Manifesto', where he notes: 'Who has not felt, in reading a text ... the need to improve it through a little judicious retouching?' From this perspective, Oulipo's interest in reframing, retelling, and translating stories – whether by the N+7 method or otherwise – appears less as a new and avant-garde departure for literature, but rather as a return to its roots, and it suggests too why the idea of the 'knitting circle', suggested in the word 'ouvrage', should have such importance for Oulipo, reminding us

as it does of the domestic scenes which formed the backdrop to the recounting of so many folk tales.

Jeux de Mots

Wordplay can hardly be claimed as an invention of Oulipo, but many of Oulipo's anticipatory plagiarists, such as Lewis Carroll and Raymond Roussel, stand out for their exuberant and audacious wordplay. Perec's *I Remember* (and this is one of the things which makes translation difficult) is full of memories of jokes involving multiple puns, such as: 'Why do musicians get up late?' 'Because of the Partita 4 in D Flat.' (In French: 'Pourquoi les filles du Nord sont-elles précoces?' 'Parce que le concerto en sol mineur.') It's not hard to see how Oulipo's concept of 'homophonic translation' – where sound remains constant as sense changes – developed out of this interest, though here as elsewhere there are numerous anticipatory plagiarisms, notably Louis Zukovsky's homophonic translation of Catullus. Perec was one of the great and obsessive masters of this form, and in his homophonic texts such as 'A Little Illustrated ABC' he pushed it to the limit, using homophonic translation to create miniature story machines.

Kick-Starts

Another Oulipian method which functions as a text generator, as well as a gentle constraint, is the '*texte à démarreur*' or 'kick-start'. Perec's *I Remember*, where each numbered memory begins with the phrase 'I remember ...', is the best-known example of this. Perec borrowed the form from New York artist Joe Brainard, and he was not the only writer to pick up on it: Ted Berrigan wrote a poem with the same title for his collection *Easter Monday* beginning 'I remember painting "I HATE TED BERRIGAN" in big black letters all over my white wall.'

Other New York School writers like Kenneth Koch had also experimented with similar repetitive forms,⁶ but Oulipo have made this form their own over the years. Anyone can write ‘I remembers’, and so Perec, in the first edition of his book, left a number of pages blank for the reader to write their own memories. Since its publication many others have tried their hand at the form, both inside and outside Oulipo, including Harry Mathews, who wrote *The Orchard* on the occasion of Perec’s death. And Oulipo have rung the changes on the idea, with other kick-starts like ‘I forget ...’, ‘Where did I read ...’, ‘Perhaps you’re one of those who ...’, and ‘I was thinking ...’, which Hervé Le Tellier turned into his book-length sequence *A Thousand Pearls (for a Thousand Pennies)*, while Étienne Léacroart has adopted the form in his strip-cartoon sequence *Vanity* (2017).

Lucretius

Lucretius’ *De Rerum Natura* (*The Poem on Nature*) supplied Oulipo with one of its key concepts in the ‘clinamen’, Lucretius’ Latin for the Greek *klesis*, ‘a bending’. The term was rescued from obscurity by Alfred Jarry, who used it for the name of his Painting Machine in his novel *Life and Opinions of Dr Faustroll, Pataphysician*. For Oulipo, it represents a moment when a particular constraint is broken, usually for aesthetic reasons – but it is something which should only be used when it is also possible to complete the writing task without breaking the constraint, and it is something which should be used sparingly. In Perec’s *Life A User’s Manual* each chapter describes one of the visible spaces in a building with 100 such spaces, but the novel contains only 99 chapters. Perec’s missing chapter is the clinamen. For Lucretius, the term has a specific sense, referring to the spontaneous deviation that allows atoms falling in otherwise parallel lines through the void to collide with one another and thus create matter. Without the clinamen, in other words, there is no creation. Elsewhere in his

argument, Lucretius likens atoms and letters, arguing that just as small changes in atomic structure can alter the nature of matter, so small changes in words can alter sense, as in the words ‘fir’ and ‘fire’. All of a sudden, Lucretius’ description of the creation of matter starts to sound uncannily like a description of Oulipian wordplay, and from this perspective clinamen can be seen to describe not just creative deviation from a rule, but the creative swerve involved in any textual manipulation, such as the N+7 method or homophonic translation.

Some recent, and some not so recent, work from Oulipo reveals a growing tendency to push the use of clinamen to the limit. Forte’s *Minute-Operas* (2005) explores a variety of fixed forms, but each constraint is disrupted and set in motion by a vertical line separating ‘stage’ and ‘wings’; Anne Garréta’s *Not One Day* (2002) carefully sets its constraints in its opening (reproduced here), only to serially abandon them as her book progresses, as if desire itself was something always in flight from constraint; while in *Saying Poetry* (1981) Jacques Roubaud, usually the strictest of Oulipians, appears to abandon constraint altogether, giving himself over to chance (there is even a nod to John Cage) and an open field poetics reminiscent of Charles Olson.

Mathematics

Remaining ever open to new possibilities in verbal art, Oulipo have on the whole resisted attempts to systematically categorize constraints. Yet mathematics, while it does not underpin every constraint – the lipogram, for example, is not mathematical – has played a key role in their thinking. It is a mathematical discovery, the creation of a 10×10 Græco-Latin bi-square, which underpins the machinery of *Life A User’s Manual*, and mathematics also plays a role in the N+7 method as it does in the combinatorial art of Queneau’s *A Hundred Thousand Billion Poems*, and the novel *One Hundred Twenty-*

One Days (2014) by mathematician-writer Michèle Audin, Chapter IX of which is structured entirely around numbers. Mathematics, too, underpins those Oulipian constraints which either shrink or expand existing texts, such as ‘haikuization’ or ‘slenderizing’, and ‘*tireur à la ligne*’ or ‘larding’, where the scale of the text is altered, techniques which in turn take us back to the games with scale practised by some of Oulipo’s most important anticipatory plagiarists, such as Jonathan Swift, in ‘A Voyage to Lilliput’ and ‘A Voyage to Brobdingnag’, and François Rabelais, in *Gargantua and Pantagruel*. And it is mathematics which, above all, has led Oulipo to create and develop new forms.

Oulipo’s collective work on the sestina is one of the clearest examples of this. From Arnaut Daniel, its inventor, to John Ashbery in the twentieth century, the sestina has remained a constant and enduring form, and the structure of the end-words of its six stanzas has been governed by the following pattern: 1-2-3-4-5-6, 6-1-5-2-4-3, 3-6-4-1-2-5, and so on up to the final stanza, 2-4-6-5-3-2. It took Queneau to make the imaginative leap that conceived of sestina-like poems with stanzas of different lengths, which he named *queninas*. In the sestina, no end-words occupy the same position twice, and Queneau noted that this only remained the case with a select group of numbers, the first few being: 1, 2, 3, 5, 6, 9, 11, 14 and 18. As Ian Monk writes: ‘Arnaut Daniel’s experiment with poetic form had thus led to the discovery of a new sequence of numbers, now known as “Queneau numbers”, one of whose main characteristics is that they obey the following formula: $2q + 1 = p$ (any Queneau number multiplied by 2, plus 1, always produces a prime number ... thus, if there really is an infinite number of primes, there is also an infinite number of Queneau numbers). Queneau observed that a vast field of research had been opened up.’⁷

New York School

Asked in interview what the connection was between Oulipo and the New York School, Harry Mathews replied: ‘There is no connection, except for me.’⁸ Mathews knew of at least one other connection, in Joe Brainard’s *I Remember*, which he had described to Perec, but beyond that there are other connections, in the work of John Ashbery, for example, who had revealed to Mathews the method of antonymic translation which became associated with Oulipo,⁹ and in the work of Ron Padgett, who had experimented with games involving noun substitution long before he became acquainted with Oulipo. This synchronicity between the interests of the New York School poets and those of Oulipo can best be explained by their shared interests in the work of Duchamp and the French surrealists, and in the work of Oulipian anticipatory plagiarists such as Robert Desnos and Raymond Roussel. This was enough to ensure that as Oulipian ideas reached the US, often via Harry Mathews, they got a warm reception, even if sometimes, too, there was an accompanying sense of déjà vu. New York School poet Bernadette Mayer, who had taught poetry workshops at St Mark’s, was one of the significant figures besides Mathews to actively disseminate Oulipian ideas across the US poetry community, teaching Charles Bernstein and Bruce Andrews among the Language poets, who in turn talked about Oulipo to Harryette Mullen among others.

Noulipo

A watershed in the Oulipian influence on the US took place at the California Institute of the Arts noulipo conference in 2005, the purpose of which was to examine the legacy of Oulipian constraint-based writing among Anglophone writers, including Bernadette Mayer, Harryette Mullen, Juliana Spahr and Christian Bök, the central figure in a cluster of Canadian conceptualists given to

Oulipian experiment. The idea of noulipo, and its specifically feminist off-shoot, foulipo, stood for a particular North American concept of Oulipo, which unlike Oulipo itself, proposed a more politically engaged use of constraint writing, exemplified in Juliana Spahr's 'HR 4811 is a joke', which attacks US anti-abortion legislation. At the conference, as Juliana Spahr and Stephanie Young began to remove their clothes during a panel, some Oulipian eyebrows were raised, but if Oulipo's purpose is to propose constraints that writers outside Oulipo are free to use in any way they want, then the possibility that writers will use constraints in ways that Oulipo themselves might not remains a constant possibility. And yet, if Oulipo itself remains unaffiliated politically as a group, individual members of Oulipo, including Jacques Roubaud and Georges Perec, have produced highly charged writings that are, in the broadest sense, nothing if not political.

Ou-x-pos

Working with Oulipo, as we have seen, Perec was able to produce not only a vast body of work, but a body of work in vastly different areas, stretching from novels to films and theatre, to cooking and music. Perec, without doubt, was a uniquely versatile writer, but his successes in writing recipes in his '81 Easy-Cook Recipes for Beginners', and in writing experimental music in his 'Memory of a Trip to Thouars' (to write 'musique aléatoire', Perec had joked, 'il faut aller à Thouars'), demonstrates that Oulipian methods can be applied to other fields beyond the literary. Perec's one excursion into music is interesting on several accounts. For one thing, if constraint is one possible way among many to go about writing, with musical composition it is something that it is almost impossible to do without, and many of the great advances in twentieth-century music, such as serialism, were effectively experiments with constraint. It is also interesting because Queneau explicitly argued that Oulipo was not an

‘aleatory’ movement. And yet, music that is composed using chance procedures, such as the music of John Cage, remains curiously close to Oulipo at times – perhaps because ‘chance’, viewed from another perspective, is not chance at all, but the exploration of a possible series of permutations, and it is notable here that both Queneau (in the prose poems in *Elementary Morality*) and Cage (in *Music of Changes*, as elsewhere) used the *I Ching*.

This insight concerning the wider applications of Oulipo was formalized by François Le Lionnais, who invented the acronym Ou-x-po to designate the generality of possible groups, where ‘x’ designates the field in question, and since the foundation of Oulipo these new groups, both official and unofficial, long- and short-lived, have continued to proliferate, and include: Ouarchipo (architecture), Oubapo (*bandes dessinées* or strip cartoons), Oucarpo (cartography), Oucuipe (cuisine), Ouhispo (history), Oulipopo (*romans policiers* or crime fiction), Oumupo (music), Oupeinpo (*peinture* or painting), Ouphopo (photography), Oupolpot (politics), Ousonmupo (*son et musique* or sound and music), Outranspo (translation), Outrapo (tragicomedy), and Ouvipo (video). Each group goes its own way with Oulipian ideas: in Oupeinpo, for example, Philippe Mouchès adapts the N+7 method by moving the action of famous paintings forward by seven seconds, while in the Oubapo Étienne Lécroart and Jean-Christophe Menu have adapted the Oulipian method of *tireur à la ligne* or larding by progressively expanding a cartoon by the systematic insertion of new frames. Many of the Ou-x-pos are represented here, some by members of the Ou-x-po in question, some by Oulipians or outsiders with parallel interests, including: Oubapo (in the work of Étienne Lécroart and Matt Madden); Oucuipe (in the work of Perec); Oulipopo (in ‘The Burning of the Abominable House’, in the work of Ian Monk, whose story ‘Spies in Newquay’ takes the form of a tale of espionage, and in Christine Brooke-Rose’s *Next*, involving murder in the homeless community); Oumupo (in the work of Perec, and in the libretto by Paul Griffiths for music by Hans

Abrahamsen); Oupeinpo (in the work of Jacques Carelman, Philippe Mouchès, Thieri Foulc, Aline Gagnaire and Édouard Levé); Ouphopo (in the work of Richard Long, whose *Dartmoor* echoes the form of Queneau's *A Hundred Thousand Billion Poems*); Outranspo (in the work of Lily Robert-Foley, and in the selection of translations of Queneau's *Exercises in Style* using the methods of Outranspo); and Ouvipo (in Valérie Beaudouin's *Body/Machine*). And perhaps Borges's 'The Garden of Forking Paths' (1941), as well as exploring infinitely bifurcating narrative possibilities, also gives a taste of what Ouhispo might look like in the alternative account it offers of events recorded in B. H. Liddell Hart's *History of World War I*. Any readers still left wanting more could do worse than turn to Umberto Eco's *The Name of the Rose*, the idea for which was obliquely suggested by Oulipopo's researches, which found that a book in which the murderer is the reader was yet to be written.

Potentielle

We have seen some of the important connotations of the word 'ouvroir' in *Ouvroir de littérature potentielle*. The word 'potentielle' is no less carefully chosen. There are at least four important and related senses here. Firstly, and most simply, 'potential literature' can be distinguished from literature in that, fundamentally, Oulipo invents or rediscovers constraints rather than writes literature. And these constraints, in the hands of Oulipians or those outside Oulipo, can *potentially* give rise to literature, even creating new possibilities for literature. A constraint, or a simple illustration of a constraint, is therefore not literature, but 'potential literature', whose real existence is virtual, in the future. This relates to a second sense, which Jacques Roubaud refers to as Oulipo's 'potential universality'. For Roubaud, this is something Oulipo shares with its two cousins, surrealism and Bourbaki, and put simply it refers to the fact that the practice of writing by constraints is conceivable in all languages. This constitutes

a powerful ‘attractive force’ which has been recognized in the US and in the UK by a variety of writers and artists, and it is one of the chief reasons why ‘oulipism’ now extends beyond oulipo and across languages. A third sense can be glimpsed in Queneau’s *A Hundred Thousand Billion Poems*, the first Oulipian work consciously conceived. This is, certainly, a work of literature, but it is also a work whose horizon remains a potentiality, for its vertiginous unleashing of 10^{14} sonnets could not in actuality be read by any single reader in a lifetime. The final sense, also hinted at in Queneau’s book, but rarely discussed in English or in French, is the mathematical sense of ‘potentielle’ in French, which refers to ‘puissance’ or power, as in raising a number to the power of 14. This exponential sense of multiplication, expressed in concrete form in Queneau’s book, is there in all Oulipian literature and all Oulipian procedures, and it represents a hidden explosive force whose ramifications – potentially – are endless, as can be seen in the ever-increasing fields explored by the Ou-x-pos.

Queneau Numbers

See under *Mathematics*.

Research

Part of Oulipo’s work, from its beginnings, has involved research into its antecedent anticipatory plagiarists. What has only come to light more recently, particularly in Michèle Métail’s research into the interpretation and reading of early Chinese palindromic poetry in her book *Wild Geese Returning: Chinese Reversible Poems*, is that Oulipian methods might themselves be the research tools necessary to read the poetry of the past. Here, it was Métail’s Oulipian background in forms such as the palindrome, which actually enabled her to read and

decipher the multiple poems concealed in these Chinese pictograms. The book offers us a unique insight into another ‘potential’ hidden in Oulipian work, the potential of Oulipian methodology to unlock works which for a long time have been closed. It is early days, but her book potentially opens up a new field of Oulipian-related research which could be used to crack the hidden code of other ancient texts, such as runes, Arabic talismanic texts, and even the Ice Age signs found in caves such as Lascaux, Chauvet and Altamira, which currently remain illegible.

Selection

Existing anthologies on the work of Oulipo, both in English and in French, fall into three broad categories: the academic, consisting mostly of essays on Oulipo, such as *Oulipo: A Primer of Potential Literature*; the anthology of constraints, usually accompanied by short illustrative texts, such as *OULIPO: L'Abécédaire provisoirement définitif* and *The Oulipo Compendium*; and anthologies which give priority to the writing itself, such as the *Anthologie de l'OuLiPo* and *The State of Constraint*. This anthology is along the lines of Gallimard's 2009 *Anthologie de l'OuLiPo*. In his preface to this book, Paul Fournel, the President of Oulipo (2003–2019), writes: ‘This anthology has no intention of being a catalogue of constraints, rather it is a collection of texts For once, the reader is not in the kitchen ... [but] seated at the table.’ The Gallimard anthology is devoted exclusively to writings by members of Oulipo, and while such writings must necessarily form the core of any Oulipian anthology, there are strong reasons for spreading the net wider, and not just to include the Ou-x-pos. A defining characteristic of Oulipo from its inception, as we have seen, has been to propose constraints for writers outside Oulipo to use, in other words a primary function of Oulipo is to propose rather than to write – and the brief illustrative texts which usually accompany new ideas from Oulipo are not always intended to be

more than illustrations, even if, in practice, they frequently transcend this provisional status. As well as containing work by Oulipians, this collection represents the work of writers outside Oulipo who have blazed the same trail, sometimes intentionally (as with Christian Bök's monovocalisms in *Eunoia*, and Christine Brooke-Rose's novel of homelessness excluding the verb 'to have', *Next*), sometimes unintentionally, or with little or no direct influence from Oulipo (as in Alice Oswald's reduction of Homer, *Memorial*, which is a perfect illustration of Oulipo's concept of slenderizing, and Inger Christensen's *alphabet*, a meditation on nature both alphabetical and underpinned by the Fibonacci sequence). One advantage of this approach is that it has enabled the inclusion of many pieces *written* in English, so that the problem of translating constraints which renders some Oulipian work in French close to untranslatable, is sidestepped. Similarly, as we have seen, an important aspect of Oulipo's research has been to discover writers from the past who anticipate their methods, Oulipo's anticipatory plagiarists, and it is impossible to give a full picture of Oulipism without including some of these writers. This sheds unexpected light on Oulipo. It is a surprise to find in *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland* a poem created by changing another poem into its opposite, thereby anticipating the method of 'antonymic translation'; and George Herbert's calligram 'Eafter Wings', which shrinks and grows as we read, in turn illuminates the Oulipian form of the snowball, and a novel such as Richard Beard's *Lazarus is Dead* (2012), the chapters of which shrink then grow again as Lazarus is reborn. (Beard's shortest chapter, where Lazarus lies dead, is reproduced here). To date, such writers have rarely featured in Oulipian anthologies, though Oulipo themselves have long cherished the as yet unrealized idea of an anthology dedicated exclusively to such anticipatory plagiarisms.

Translation

Given that so much writing by Oulipo is in French, and that even some English-speaking members of Oulipo, like Ian Monk, write principally in French, the problem of translation arises. Robert Frost famously claimed that what gets lost in translation is poetry, and it is immediately tempting in this context to say that what gets lost in translation is Oulipo. Georges Perec's e-less novel *La Disparition* is a case in point. The correct translation of the title would be *The Disappearance*, but already the constraint has been broken three times. The first sentence of Chapter 1 in the novel reads: 'Anton Voyl n'arrivait pas à dormir'. This could be translated as 'Anton Voyl couldn't manage to get to sleep', or more colloquially 'Anton Voyl was having trouble getting to sleep'. Either way, the e's creep in. Translators, then, are faced with a decision: either translate the text before you or translate the constraint, allowing the inevitable departures from strict sense that this entails. Fortunately, we have been blessed with some very creative translators when it comes to Oulipo, among them David Bellos and Gilbert Adair. So Adair, throwing caution to the wind, and choosing to inhabit the constraint, translates the opening of Perec's first chapter like this: 'Incurably insomniac, Anton Voyl turns on a light.'

Untranslatability

I would tend to agree with David Bellos that nothing is untranslatable. However, with Oulipo, the harder the constraint, the further apart the literal and the constraint-based translations become, to the point where, in the latter case, the translation is close to becoming a new work. To date, the books by Perec that nobody has translated into English are the poems, simply because the constraints here are so strict. The poems have, though, been translated into German. Jürgen Ritte, commenting on Oskar Pastior's translations,

which use the same constraints as Perec, notes: ‘this makes completely different poems, but the “translation” is faithful in its own way.’¹⁰ Translating a text like Perec’s ‘A Little Illustrated ABC’ presents similar problems. When Perec homophonically translates ‘Ta-Te-Ti-To-Tu’, he gets ‘Tâté, Tito tut’ (literally ‘Sounded out, Tito is silent’), but a translator with an eye on the constraint – and here constraint is everything – has to come up with something which may have quite a different sense, even if ‘Tito’ here is easy to hang on to, such as ‘Tatty Tito too’ or ‘Tati, Tito: O’Toole’, which when expanded into a miniature narrative in Perec’s manner is likely to give a completely different result. Literally, such texts are untranslatable, but a sensitive translation of the constraint can give the work ‘continued life’, in Walter Benjamin’s phrase.

Variations

First published in 1947, thirteen years before the foundation of Oulipo, Queneau’s *Exercises in Style*, where he retells in 99 variations a single story about an incident on a crowded bus, proved to be a text of lasting and unforeseeable importance for Oulipo. The idea came to Queneau in the 1930s after he and his friend Michel Leiris had attended a concert at the Salle Pleyel where Bach’s *The Art of the Fugue* had been performed. What struck Queneau was that, although based on a slight theme, the variations proliferated endlessly, almost infinitely, and Queneau wondered if a similar exercise could be performed with written texts. *Exercises in Style* is his resounding answer to this, and its endless proliferations have continued to unfold in the work of Oulipo, making it a key work of ‘potential literature’. Seeing this, Queneau revised the work in 1973, removing six variations that he considered unsatisfactory, and replacing them with overtly Oulipian variations – ‘Set Theory’ (inspired by Bourbaki), ‘Definitional’, ‘Tanka’, ‘Translation’ (using the method N+6), ‘Lipogram’, and ‘Geometric’ – all of which are here translated for the

first time in English. Taking their cue from Queneau, other Oulipians have turned their hands to the variation, among them Harry Mathews, both in his '35 Variations on a Theme from Shakespeare' and his *Trial Impressions*. Other Oulipians have ploughed the same furrow, with variations and responses to Queneau: Jacques Carelman, of Oupeinpo, added 33 visual interpretations of Queneau for an edition of *Exercises in Style* published in 1963, and in 2006 Matt Madden, of Oubapo, responded with his strip cartoon variations in *99 Ways To Tell A Story*. Perhaps less well recognized is the impact that Queneau's variations have had on some of the major works of the Oulipo: for in this context many of Calvino's works can be seen to be of this type, such as *The Castle of Crossed Destinies*, which offers intricate variations on classic stories and myths, and his masterpiece *Invisible Cities*, which, in essence, is a series of variations on descriptions of Venice presented by Marco Polo to Kublai Khan. Perhaps the most remarkable of all Oulipian variations is the sequence of narratives collected under the title ...

Winter Journeys

Perc's *The Winter Journey* appeared for the first time in 1980, almost secretly, in a publicity bulletin put out by Hachette. The hero, Vincent Degraël – to cut a short story even shorter – comes across a slim volume of poetry entitled *The Winter Journey* by an unknown author, Hugo Vernier. The volume is full of echoes of many of the great poets of nineteenth-century France, and at first Degraël takes it for a work of plagiarism, until he notices the date of publication, which falls way before the dates of the writers it appears to copy. It is not, it turns out, a work of plagiarism, but a work of anticipatory plagiarism: Degraël has discovered the unacknowledged wellspring of nineteenth-century French poetry, or so it would appear – but at this point the story is interrupted by the Second World War, and when Degraël returns to France in 1945 his attempts to trace the volume

again prove fruitless, and he ends his days in the psychiatric hospital in Verrières. Perec's slim volume is a remarkable work in itself, a deft and playful parable condensing many of the ideas he had learnt as an active member of Oulipo. What Perec couldn't have predicted, though, was the way in which other members of Oulipo, beginning with Roubaud, would respond to his work, ringing the changes on its themes in a still-growing series of variations, which in their seemingly endless proliferations, turn Perec's text into one of Oulipo's definitive works of 'potential literature'. To date, there are twenty-one variations on this story, and counting, which have appeared in French in the Bibliothèque Oulipienne (the Oulipo Library). They are represented here by Perec's inaugural tale, by François Caradec's 'The Worm's Journey', and by the story by Valérie Beaudouin (writing as Hugo Vernier), 'Hell's Journey'.

X takes Y for Z

A fitting conclusion to this alphabetical introduction to Oulipo is the constraint, devised by Queneau, of X takes Y for Z. Illustrated in the form of a multiplication table, it describes fictional cases of mistaken identity. In a normal situation, each character knows who they are and who the others are:

	x	y	z
x	x	y	z
y	x	y	z
z	x	y	z

Yet in other cases, such as y and z being identical twins, confusions arise:

	x	y	z
x	x	z	y
y	x	y	z
z	x	y	z

In Perec's 'Sentimental Tales', included here, the method is adapted to describe who characters are – or appear to be – in love with.